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Joseph Banks: the botanist who built a network

Joseph Banks (1743-1820) was a British naturalist with money enough to turn curiosity into cargo. In 1766 he collected in Newfoundland and Labrador. In 1768 he joined Cook on Endeavour. Daniel Solander classified. Sydney Parkinson drew. A dried plant, a label, and a drawing are a scientific record. They are a European record. People who already grew or gathered those plants had not been waiting for a London name.

What traveled home was not a conquest of the plant. A pressed specimen keeps a shape. Parkinson's drawing keeps a color the dried sheet loses. Solander's name puts the plant in a European cabinet. None of those three objects moves the people who already cooked the leaves or fruit. The cabinet is a record of a visit. It is not a discovery in the sense of finding an empty world.

Banks came home in 1771. He did not go on Cook's second voyage. In 1772 he sailed to Iceland instead. From 1778 until he died in 1820 he was president of the Royal Society. He advised King George III and had a long influence on the gardens at Kew. Influence is the right word. He was not the formal director of Kew, and this lesson will not give him that title.

He is also the organizer of the breadfruit voyages, not their captain. The plan was to move a living Pacific crop to the Caribbean as cheap food for enslaved plantation workers. The packing of living trees was ingenious. The purpose sat inside an empire that ran on forced labor. Both sentences belong in the account. The voyage itself, and the mutiny that stopped the first attempt, are told with the Bounty. The plant is told in the breadfruit lesson.

One warning about the name. Jos. A. Bank, the Baltimore clothier, is a different man and a different century. The botanist has a final s. The firm usually does not. Nothing in Banks's career is a clothing chain, and this page will not invent one.

The link back to Cook is the ship they shared in 1768. The link forward is the crate of breadfruit trees Banks wanted sent, and the American firm that only looks like his name. A label in a cabinet is not a deed to the plant, and a presidency is not a captain's log.

The illustrated lesson is download the PDF.

Sources

- Natural History Museum, "Joseph Banks: scientist, explorer, botanist," https://www.nhm.ac.uk/discover/joseph-banks-scientist-explorer-botanist.html

- Royal Botanic Gardens, Kew, history of the gardens: https://www.kew.org/about-us/history-of-kew
- Royal Society note on Banks: https://royalsociety.org/science-events-and-lectures/2017/09/joseph-banks/

Key facts

- Banks (1743-1820) collected in Newfoundland and Labrador in 1766 and sailed on Endeavour in 1768 with Solander and Parkinson.
- He returned in 1771, did not join Cook's second voyage, and went to Iceland in 1772.
- President of the Royal Society 1778-1820. He advised the king and influenced Kew. He was not Kew's formal director.
- He organized the breadfruit missions. He was not captain of the Bounty. He is not the clothier Jos. A. Bank.